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**Sub Region:** Eastern Africa

**Field Date:** 1959-1960

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**Place Coverage**

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**Section Title(S):** SEXUAL LICENSE • SOCIAL OBLIGATIONS

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Lest this account of what is permitted by custom distort the picture it should be noted that: (a) pre-marital and extra-marital sex relations are by no means limited to watani; (b) while affairs between watani are not condemned by the majority, neither are they encouraged, for it is rather a case of "since one must, it is better to seek out a mtani;" and (c) while it was conceded that most widowed or divorced women had at least an occasional affair, such behavior was considered unbecoming in married women. Moreover, pre-marital promiscuity was not as prevalent as might be assumed from the comments above about cross-cousins. Pre-marital sex relations were condemned unless the participants were cross-cousins or at least watani. Among other things the puberty rites for girls remove them from circulation for a considerable period of time following menarche. At this time they are isolated in a darkened room for from one to two years, emerging only to go to the latrine. During this period they receive instructions from designated female kin about sex and marriage, communicate only with women, move but little, and are fattened up for their debut. Traditionally, the marriage arrangements should be settled before their "coming out" party, an elaborate affair involving a day or two of dancing and beer-drinking, and the wedding should occur at the time they are returned to society, or shortly thereafter. While it is difficult to document, it appears that premarital sexual relationships and pregnancy are increasing because of the departure from this traditional practice of marriage shortly after the period of isolation. Length of confinement is being shortened, or in the case of some schoolgirls, eliminated entirely. Also, young men have difficulty acquiring the inflated bridewealth. Thus the period between the coming-out ceremony and marriage is considerably lengthened, thus increasing the opportunity for pre-marital sexual activity for many girls.

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## SOCIAL OBLIGATIONS

In one respect, utani may be defined as a jural relationship, for it must be viewed in terms of duties and obligations as well as rights and privileges. The obligatory aspect may be noted primarily at times of crises, such as birth, death, and disputes. Many examples could be cited, but the most common is the required presence of watani at burials. When someone dies, the neighbors and relatives may be notified by calling the message from house to house and farm to farm across the mountain, but the elders of the watani clan or clans of the deceased should be informed by messenger with a small gift of money. The function of the watani, in addition to the joking noted above, is assisting the clan in preparation of the body and interment. This includes washing the  1321 corpse, making the shroud, digging the grave, carrying the body to the grave, and burial. The watani clan would be offended if they were not notified, for in addition to the slight, it would deprive them of their right to get even regarding confiscation of food. A recent development sometimes observed involves a payment of cash for sewing the shroud or washing the body, which varies from four to eighteen shillings, a stipened that a mtani is reluctant to pass up.

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